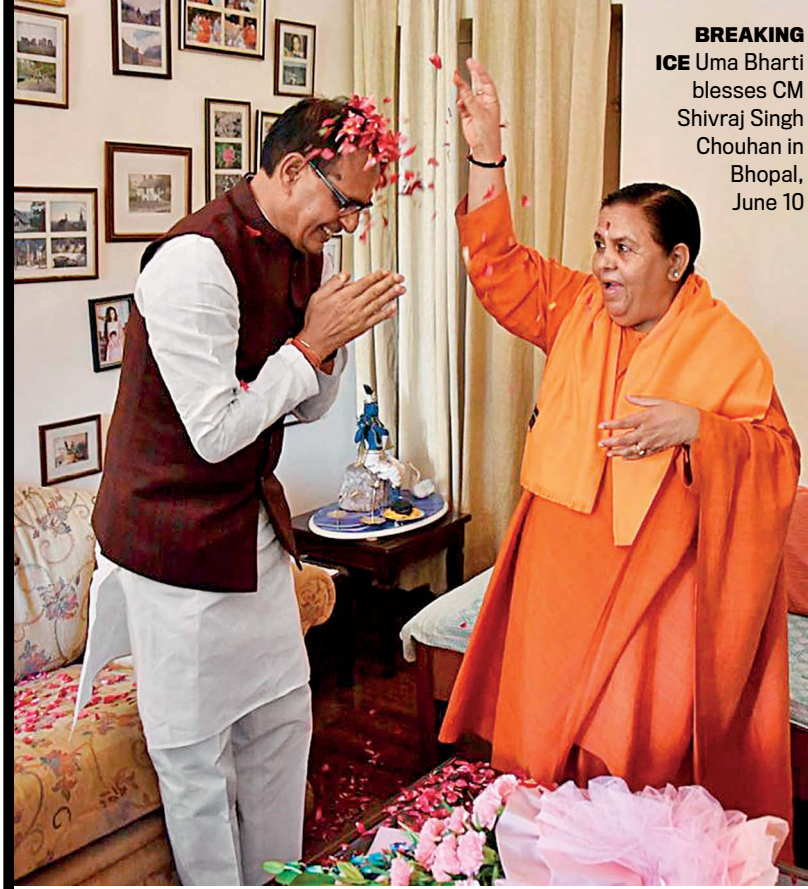
authored a paper for the NITI Aayog on simultaneous polls, and in August 2018, the Law Commission held that amending the Constitution is imperative to implementing a One Nation, One Poll system. The commission had recommended syncing assembly elections with the 2019 Lok Sabha polls by extending or reducing the tenures of a few state legislatures, such as those of Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Mizoram, Rajasthan, Haryana, Jharkhand, Maharashtra and Delhi. For other states, the commission had suggested that elections be held towards the end of 2021, over two years after the Lok Sabha polls.

Raking up the subject once again, the Modi government hopes to see the ONOP idea through to fulfilment this time. But it's a daunting task, and the outcome may not exactly be on favourable terms. There is the key challenge of managing varying perceptions for the state and Lok Sabha elections, especially in states where regional parties have a stronger hold. Beyond that is the mammoth problem of mobilising support from various political parties and stakeholders and readying up a robust polling infrastructure, including a large number of additional electronic voting and paper trail machines.

The ONOP system has its pros and cons. With simultaneous Lok Sabha and state elections, governance may be relatively smoother given that there won't be disruptions due to the imposition of the Model Code of Conduct ahead of each poll. At the same time, there are worries that an ONOP system could lead to national issues taking centrestage and the 'Modi factor' looming large during electioneering, eclipsing regional concerns and hurting smaller parties. The Kovind committee will have to take these and other factors into account to come up with a comprehensive, just and credible approach that's centred not on political but national good. ■



BREAKING ICE Uma Bharti blesses CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan in Bhopal, June 10

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MADHYA PRADESH

CONVERGING INTERESTS

By Rahul Noronha

On August 26, three new ministers were inducted in the Shivraj Singh Chouhan cabinet in poll-bound Madhya Pradesh. Two of them, Rajendra Shukla and Gauri Shankar Bisen, are senior MLAs, former ministers and Shivraj loyalists, so their new cabinet posts caused no surprise. However, behind the inclusion of the third—Khargapur MLA Rahul Singh Lodhi, who was sworn in as a minister of state—political observers detect the BJP's caste compulsions before the polls as well as a growing entente between the current chief minister and his one-time predecessor and senior BJP leader Uma Bharti. Lodhi happens to be Bharti's nephew.

Shivraj and Bharti have been bitter rivals in the past. In 2003, as the BJP's chief ministerial candidate, Bharti won a landslide in Madhya Pradesh, ending 10 years of Congress rule. She resigned in 2004 in a national flag dishonour case and was replaced by Babulal Gaur, who in turn made way for Shivraj in late 2005. Shivraj's appointment and firm backing by the high command was a blow to Bharti, who had planned a comeback. Shivraj soon found her to be an implacable critic perennially seeking his ouster. Expelled from the BJP in 2006 due to 'indiscipline', Bharti formed the Bharatiya Jan Shakti Party, but eventually merged it with the BJP in 2011. Bharti contested and won in the